Keyword Research & SEO Priorities for a Book-Services Website (US/UK/CA/AU Authors)

Bottom line: your best path to page 1 is to lead with children's book illustration and publishing, book cover design, and author website design. reedsy **Treat ghostwriting as a service you sell, not one you try to rank for.** Ghostwriting has the highest-value clicks, but those results are crowded with marketplaces, elite US agencies and a large number of clone sites run from Pakistan. Writer Beware, an author-protection watchdog, says in its "Best of Writer Beware: 2025 in Review" (January 2026) that "Ghostwriting scams, which pose as publishing service providers, are also based overseas, primarily in Pakistan", so a new Karachi-based site starts with a trust handicap there.

TL;DR

- **Go after first:** children's book illustration and publishing, book cover design (genre and KDP long-tails), and author website design. Each has clear buyer intent, a realistic difficulty level for a new domain, and work you can show visually. Author websites also fit your web-design strengths.
- **Second wave:** editing (proofreading folded in) and self-publishing/KDP services. There is real demand, but Reedsy, BookBaby and established self-publishing companies hold the head terms. Win with niche, genre and platform-specific pages ("IngramSpark setup", "memoir editing"), not "book editing services".
- **Avoid as an SEO lead (for now):** head terms like "ghostwriting services" and standalone "proofreading services". Ghostwriting results are saturated and carry reputation risk for Pakistan-based sellers. Proofreading is low-ticket and already owned by specialists. Sell both as add-ons, and only go after niche ghostwriting long-tails once you have verifiable proof.

Data sources and confidence (read this first)

Live DataForSEO access was not available during this research, so the numbers come from three tiers. Label them the same way in your own planning:

Tier	What it means	Where it came from
Verified (published third-party data)	Figures copied from a public keyword or analytics page	AdTargeting's publishing keyword list (Google Ads-based **global** volume, CPC and *paid* difficulty, page copyright 2022). adtargeting Semrush public domain pages (2026)
Observed	What actually shows up in search results and on competitor sites	SERP checks for the money keywords, competitor pricing pages
Estimate	My judgement-based ranges for US volume, KD and CPC where no public figure was found	Marked "Est." in the tables. **Check these in DataForSEO or Keyword Planner before committing budget**

Two caveats on the verified data. AdTargeting's volumes are global, not US-only; the US is typically about half or more of global English demand for these terms. Its "PD" is paid-ad difficulty, not organic KD. adtargeting

Key Findings

1. **Self-publishing is the biggest pool, but the money terms are hard.** Verified global data: "amazon self publishing" 35,000/mo (CPC $4.55), "how to publish a book" 27,100 ($2.69), "self publishing" 22,200 ($3.11), "kindle self publishing" 7,500 ($4.09), "kdp self publishing" 4,100 ($4.90). adtargeting Most of that is informational. The commercial head term "self publishing company" gets only 2,900/mo but has a $6.11 CPC and PD 81. "Book publishing companies" gets 5,400 at $5.71, and "book publishing companies near me" has a $6.93 CPC. adtargeting Those CPCs show that buyers exist and advertisers fight over them.
2. **Children's publishing is a clear high-intent cluster.** "Children's book publishers" gets 8,100/mo at $3.99 CPC and "how to publish a children's book" gets 4,400/mo at $4.04 CPC (PD 78). "Childrens book publishers" (1,300) and "kids book publishers" (1,000) add more. adtargeting The ticket size is large: based on thousands of quotes on its marketplace, Reedsy says illustrators charge "$60 and $200 for a single-page illustration, and between $100 and $400 for a two-page spread", and that "it can cost between $2,000 and $10,000 to hire an illustrator to work on a full picture book." The Australian Society of Authors' 2026/27 recommended rate is **A$6,409+** for a 32-page picture book. You get high value per client without needing ghostwriting-level trust.
3. **Proofreading is already owned.** Semrush shows "proofreading services" at **1,900/mo, CPC $3.22, with informational intent**. Proofreadingservices.com ranks #1 and gets about 293.6K monthly visits. semrush semrush Reedsy's average proofreading rate is **$20 per 1,000 words** and developmental editing averages **$36 per 1,000 words**. reedsy Proofreading is low-ticket, and the search results are claimed.
4. **Ghostwriting is high-value but structurally hostile to a new Pakistan-based site.** Writer Beware describes ghostwriting scams as "based overseas, primarily in Pakistan and India". writerbeware One network it documented in "USA Pen Press: The Ghostwriting Scam of a Thousand Websites" (January 2025) ran **29 websites**. Its 2025 review puts it this way: "Well, not a thousand. But twenty-nine isn't too shabby–all falsely using the names of famous writers." Trustpilot reviews name a "Karachi-based scam network". trustpilot Selfpublishing.com reviews Book Writing Inc. as an LA-branded "Pakistani company that owns many similar writing/publishing companies". selfpublishing At the premium end, Scribe Professional is **$56,000** and Kevin Anderson & Associates quotes **$57,500–$250,000**. yourtale builtwritten A new site is squeezed between those agencies and Fiverr/Upwork/Reedsy.
5. **Marketplaces take a large share of page 1.** Fiverr has category pages with **31,000+** children's book illustration gigs and **8,000+** ghostwriting gigs. fiverr fiverr Reedsy (Semrush Authority Score about 67–68, about 4.3–4.6M visits/month) has category pages for editing (1,900+ editors), reedsy ghostwriting (250+ ghostwriters) and author website design. semrush +3 For most head terms, expect 2–4 page-1 slots to go to marketplaces and guide sites. The slots you can realistically win are in long-tails, genre pages and cost pages.
6. **Author website design is low-volume, but niche specialists win it.** Rocket Expansion, a small specialist agency, says it ranks top 3 for "author website design services" and "best author website designs", and for 100+ related terms. rocketexpansion That shows a focused site with good portfolio content can win this cluster.

Details by Service

Keyword tables

Legend: **V** = verified (source noted), **Est.** = my estimate (US monthly). KD bands: Low <30, Med 30–50, High 50–70, Very High 70+. Intent: T = transactional/commercial, I = informational.

1. Ghostwriting

Keyword	US vol	KD	CPC	Intent
ghostwriter	Est. 15k–30k	Very High	Est. $3–8	Mixed (lots of definition/jobs)
ghostwriting services	Est. 2k–5k	Very High	Est. $8–20	T
hire a ghostwriter	Est. 1k–2k	High	Est. $8–15	T
book ghostwriter / ghostwriter for a book	Est. 1k–3k	High	Est. $6–15	T
how much does a ghostwriter cost	Est. 1k–2k	Med	Est. $3–8	I→T
memoir ghostwriter	Est. 500–1k	Med	Est. $5–12	T
children's book ghostwriter	Est. 200–500	Low–Med	Est. $3–8	T
christian book ghostwriter / business book ghostwriter	Est. 100–400 each	Low–Med	Est. $5–12	T
Verdict: AVOID as an SEO lead. Treat it as a sales add-on. Later, go after genre long-tails (children's, faith-based, memoir for families) with real case studies.				

2. Proofreading

Keyword	US vol	KD	CPC	Intent
proofreading services	**V: 1,900 (Semrush)**	High (Est.)	**V: $3.22**	I/T mixed semrush
book proofreading services	Est. 200–500	Med	Est. $3–6	T
manuscript proofreading	Est. 100–300	Low–Med	Est. $3–6	T
proofreading cost per word	Est. 300–800	Med	Est. $2–4	I
Verdict: LOW PRIORITY standalone. Put it in the editing cluster as one sub-page.				

3. Editing

Keyword	US vol	KD	CPC	Intent
book editing services	Est. 1k–2.5k	High	Est. $4–9	T
book editor / manuscript editor	Est. 3k–8k	High	Est. $3–7	Mixed
developmental editing services	Est. 300–700	Med	Est. $4–8	T
book editing cost / how much does it cost to edit a book	Est. 500–1.5k	Med	Est. $3–6	I→T
children's book editor	Est. 200–500	Low–Med	Est. $3–6	T
memoir / fantasy / romance editor	Est. 100–400 each	Low	Est. $3–6	T
"editorial companies"	**V: 900 global, CPC $2.99, PD 34 (AdTargeting)** adtargeting	—	—	T
Verdict: GOOD (second wave). The head term is owned by Reedsy, BookBaby, Palmetto, Editage and Taylor & Francis. Win with genre-specific editing pages and a transparent per-word price page.				

4. Publishing on platforms (self-publishing / KDP / IngramSpark)

Keyword	Vol	CPC	PD / KD	Intent
amazon self publishing	**V: 35,000 global**	**$4.55**	PD 26 adtargeting	I (Amazon/KDP dominate)
self publishing	**V: 22,200**	**$3.11**	PD 59 adtargeting	I
kindle self publishing	**V: 7,500**	**$4.09**	PD 15 adtargeting	I
kdp self publishing	**V: 4,100**	**$4.90**	PD 9 adtargeting	I
book publishing companies	**V: 5,400**	**$5.71**	PD 67 adtargeting	T
self publishing company	**V: 2,900**	**$6.11**	PD 81 adtargeting	T
best self publishing companies	**V: 1,900**	**$5.09**	PD 74 adtargeting	Commercial investigation
cost to publish a book	**V: 1,300**	**$3.44**	PD 54 adtargeting	I→T
publishing services	**V: 900**	**$3.23**	PD 21 adtargeting	T
self publishing uk / book publishers uk	**V: 1,300 / 1,600**	$2.87 / $2.69	PD 91 / 82 adtargeting	T (UK)
book publishers australia	**V: 900**	$2.51	PD 75 adtargeting	T (AU)
KDP publishing services / IngramSpark publishing help	Est. 100–500 each	Est. $3–6	Low–Med	T

(V = AdTargeting, global volume, Google Ads-based.)

Verdict: GOOD. Use the informational volume ("how to publish on KDP", "KDP vs IngramSpark") as a

Keyword	Vol	CPC	PD / KD	Intent
content hub. Sell “done-for-you KDP + IngramSpark publishing” as the money page. Don’t chase “self publishing company” in year 1.				

5. Illustrations (general)

Keyword	US vol	KD	CPC	Intent
book illustration services	Est. 200–600	Med	Est. $2–5	T
book illustrator for hire	Est. 200–500	Low–Med	Est. $2–5	T
comic book / graphic novel illustrator for hire	Est. 200–600	Med	Est. $2–4	T
map illustration for fantasy books	Est. 100–300	Low	Est. $1–3	T
Verdict: GOOD, but merge it into the children’s book and cover clusters. General “illustration” searches are mostly about inspiration and art.				

6. Children’s books (writing + illustration + publishing)

Keyword	Vol	CPC	KD/PD	Intent
children's book publishers	**V: 8,100 global**	**$3.99**	PD 88 adtargeting	T (many want trad publishers)
how to publish a children's book	**V: 4,400**	**$4.04**	PD 78 adtargeting	I→T
childrens book publishers / kids book publishers	**V: 1,300 / 1,000**	$3.97 / $3.48	PD 83 / 94 adtargeting	T
children's book illustrator	Est. 2k–5k	Est. $2–5	Med–High	T
children's book illustration services	Est. 300–800	Est. $3–6	Med	T
children's book illustrators for hire	Est. 300–700	Est. $3–6	Med	T
how much does it cost to illustrate a children's book	Est. 500–1.5k	Est. $2–4	Low–Med	I→T
picture book illustration / self publish a picture book	Est. 200–600 each	Est. $2–5	Low–Med	T
watercolor / Black / Muslim / bilingual children's book illustrator	Est. 50–300 each	Est. $2–5	Low	T

Keyword	Vol	CPC	KD/PD	Intent
Verdict: BEST. This cluster has the best mix of intent, ticket size and long-tail depth. On ticket size, Reedsy reports that "over the past three years, the average children's book illustrator on Reedsy has charged between $1,540 and $4,950 for a 24-page picture book." Package writing, illustration, formatting and KDP into one offer.				

7. Author website

Keyword	US vol	KD	CPC	Intent
author website	Est. 1.5k–4k	Med	Est. $2–5	Mixed (examples/DIY)
author website design	Est. 300–800	Low–Med	Est. $4–10	T
author website design services / author web designer	Est. 100–300	Low–Med	Est. $5–12	T
author website examples / best author websites	Est. 500–1.5k	Med	Est. $1–3	I (link-magnet)
author website cost / WordPress for authors / Squarespace vs WordPress for authors	Est. 100–400 each	Low	Est. $3–6	I→T
Verdict: BEST (an easy win). Volume is low, but competition is light and buyers convert. It is your core web skill and can bring monthly care-plan revenue.				

8. Book cover design

Keyword	US vol	KD	CPC	Intent
book cover design	Est. 10k–20k	High	Est. $1–3	Mixed (DIY/inspiration)
book cover designer	Est. 2k–4k	High	Est. $2–5	T
book cover design services	Est. 500–1.5k	Med–High	Est. $3–7	T
custom book cover design	Est. 300–800	Med	Est. $3–6	T
book cover design cost / price	Est. 300–800	Low–Med	Est. $2–4	I→T
KDP cover design / kindle cover size	Est. 500–2k	Low–Med	Est. $1–3	I→T
fantasy / romance / thriller / children's book cover designer	Est. 100–600 each	Low–Med	Est. $2–5	T
book cover maker / creator (DIY, avoid)	**V: 4,400 each (Semrush via diybookcovers.com page)**	—	**$1.22**	I (tool seekers) semrush
Verdict: BEST. Go after genre long-tails and KDP-specific pages. Avoid "book cover maker"-type DIY terms, which are tool seekers rather than buyers.				

Who ranks on page 1 and how strong they are

Money keyword	Who you'll see (observed)	Strength	Can a new site rank?
ghostwriting services / hire a ghostwriter	Reedsy, Fiverr, Upwork, Scribe Media, Kevin Anderson & Associates, Gotham, many "best ghostwriting services" listicles, and clone agencies with paid listicles derekdemars	Very high; listicle wars	Not in year 1. Niche long-tails only
book editing services	Reedsy (from $20/1k words), reedsy BookBaby, Palmetto, Taylor & Francis, Editage, Scribendi, roundup posts	High	Genre/cost long-tails in 3–6 months
proofreading services	proofreadingservices.com (#1, ~294K visits/mo), Scribendi, academic editors	High	No (head term) semrush semrush
self publishing company	BookBaby, Palmetto, Lulu, IngramSpark, Kindlepreneur/Reedsy guides, review sites	Very high (PD 81)	No. Platform-specific long-tails only
book cover design services	Fiverr, Damonza, MiblArt, BookBaby, Palmetto, 100Covers, CreativIndie, BookCoverZone, designer directories fiverr +7	Medium-high, fragmented	Yes for genre and KDP long-tails in 3–6 months
children's book illustrator for hire	Fiverr (31,000+ gigs), Reedsy guides, selfpublishing.com, Self-Publishing School, specialist studios	Medium	Yes, with a strong portfolio and cost page fiverr
author website design	Reedsy, small specialists (Rocket Expansion, Outbox), Dribbble rocketexpansion +3	Low-medium	Yes, the fastest win

What it means: mid-tier specialist studios (MiblArt, Damonza, Rocket Expansion) already rank alongside the giants for design-led services. That is your proof that a focused, portfolio-heavy site can break in. Ghostwriting and self-publishing-company terms are fought over with paid listicles and big brands, and no realistic budget changes that in year 1.

Low-Competition, High-Intent Opportunities to Win Fast

- **Children's book niches:** "Muslim children's book illustrator", "bilingual children's book illustration", "children's book about autism illustrator", "Black children's book illustrator", "Christian children's book illustration", "watercolor picture book illustrator", "illustrate a children's book for KDP", "board book illustration". Write each page around portfolio samples.

- **Cost pages** (intent switches from informational to buying): “children’s book illustration cost per page”, “book cover design cost”, “author website cost”, “cost to self-publish a children’s book” (parent term “cost to publish a book” is V: 1,300, $3.44). adtargeting
- **Platform-specific publishing:** “KDP formatting service”, “IngramSpark cover template help”, “publish a hardcover on KDP”, “KDP vs IngramSpark for children’s books”, “Barnes & Noble Press publishing service”.
- **Author-website niches:** “author website for self-published authors”, “children’s author website”, “romance author website design”, “author website with email list (MailerLite/ConvertKit)”, “author website redesign”.
- **Genre cover pages:** “fantasy book cover design”, “romance book cover designer”, “cozy mystery cover design”, “series book cover design”, “audiobook cover design”.
- **Geo modifiers (lower priority):** “book cover designer UK”, “self-publishing services Canada”, “children’s book illustrator Australia”. These are worth doing as single regional landing pages once the core pages rank. Verified UK and AU publishing terms (“book publishers uk” 1,600; “book publishers australia” 900) show demand, but PD is high (75–91). adtargeting

Recommended Site Structure and Keyword-to-Page Mapping

Page	Primary keyword	Supporting long-tails	Type
/childrens-book-services/ (pillar)	children's book illustration and publishing	how to publish a children's book	Pillar
/childrens-book-illustration/	children's book illustration services	children's book illustrator for hire, picture book illustration	Money
/childrens-book-illustration-cost/	children's book illustration cost	cost per page, 32-page picture book price	Pricing
/childrens-book-illustration/[style-or-niche]/ (4–6 pages)	watercolor / Muslim / bilingual / Christian children's book illustrator	—	Niche money
/book-cover-design/ (pillar)	book cover design services	custom book cover design, book cover designer	Money
/book-cover-design/[genre]/ (5–8 pages)	fantasy/romance/thriller/children's/non-fiction cover design	series covers	Niche money
/book-cover-design-cost/	book cover design cost	KDP cover price	Pricing
/author-website-design/	author website design	author website design services, author web designer	Money
/author-website-examples/	author website examples	best author websites	Link magnet
/self-publishing-services/ (pillar)	self-publishing services	KDP publishing services, IngramSpark publishing	Money

Page	Primary keyword	Supporting long-tails	Type
/kdp-publishing-service/ & /ingramspark-publishing-service/	KDP publishing service	KDP formatting, hardcover KDP	Money
/book-editing-services/ (+ /proofreading/, /developmental-editing/)	book editing services	manuscript proofreading, children's book editor	Money
/ghostwriting/ (one page, no cluster yet)	children's book / memoir ghostwriting	—	Money (low SEO push)
/portfolio/ + /case-studies/	brand + "[book title] cover"	—	Trust
/about/ (real team, real Karachi location, real contracts)	brand	—	Trust (E-E-A-T)

Blog and comparison topics (in priority order): KDP vs IngramSpark for children's books; How much does it cost to self-publish a children's book (with real line items); Children's book trim sizes and bleed for KDP; Book cover design checklist by genre; What an author website needs; Reedsy vs Fiverr vs a studio for book covers (honest comparison); How to spot a publishing scam (positions you as the trustworthy option); Developmental vs line vs copy editing vs proofreading.

Roadmap

Months 0–3 (foundation and fast wins)

- Build a technically clean site (fast, mobile, schema for Service, FAQPage, Organization and Review). Publish the 3 pillars: children's books, covers, author websites.
- Publish 2 cost pages (illustration cost, cover cost) and the author-website-examples page.
- Ship 4 children's-niche illustration pages and 4 genre cover pages, each with 6–12 portfolio pieces and a visible price "from $X".
- Target: page-1 rankings for author-website long-tails and 2–3 niche children's illustration terms, and first leads from cost pages.

Months 4–6 (expand the winning clusters)

- Add KDP and IngramSpark service pages plus the "KDP vs IngramSpark" guide. Add editing pages split by genre, with proofreading as a sub-page.

- Run digital PR and links: guest posts on author blogs, podcast interviews, author-community resources, and a free "KDP cover size calculator" or "picture book page planner" tool as a link magnet.
- Target: top 5 for "children's book illustration cost"-type terms, top 10 for 2–3 genre cover terms, and page 2 for "author website design".

Months 7–12 (go after the bigger terms)

- Push toward "children's book illustrator for hire", "book cover design services" and "author website design". Add UK/CA/AU landing pages where data shows traction.
- Only now add a ghostwriting cluster (children's book ghostwriter, memoir ghostwriter), and only with named writers, verifiable samples and contracts.
- Target: page 1 for at least one mid-volume money term per BEST cluster, and a meaningful share of leads from organic search instead of ads.

Local/Geographic Considerations and Marketplace Effects

- **US first:** it has the largest demand and the highest CPCs. Write in US English, price in USD and show US-friendly payment terms. Add GBP/CAD/AUD display later.
- **UK/AU need separate pages:** verified UK/AU publishing terms show high paid difficulty (PD 75–91). adtargeting Use hreflang only if you build true regional variants. Otherwise use single landing pages with regional proof (UK spelling options, local platform notes such as Waterstones, or Ingram distribution in Australia).
- **Be honest about where you are.** The Karachi-run "fake US address" pattern is exactly what Writer Beware and Trustpilot reviewers flag. trustpilot writerbeware Showing real staff, real Karachi offices, verifiable portfolios and escrow-style milestone payments is ethical, and it is also a competitive advantage in a field full of fakes. Never use fake US addresses, borrowed bestseller covers or fake reviews. Those are the practices that get these clone sites exposed. writersweekly americapublishersauthorspotl...
- **Marketplaces:** Fiverr, Upwork and Reedsy will keep head-term slots because of their huge authority (Reedsy has a Semrush Authority Score of about 67–68). semrush semrush Use them rather than fight them: keep a Reedsy, Fiverr or Upwork profile as a lead channel and review generator, and use your site to win long-tails where marketplace category pages are weak (niche styles, bundled packages, cost explainers).
- **AI Overviews:** informational queries ("how to publish on KDP") lose clicks to AI summaries. A Pew Research Center study (July 2025, browsing data from 900 US adults) found that users who saw an AI summary clicked a traditional search result in 8% of visits, against 15% for users who didn't. It also found that "60% of search queries that began with question words… resulted in an AI summary" (Google disputes Pew's methodology). Commercial and transactional service queries are affected less. Put most effort into service, cost and comparison pages with FAQ schema and named experts. pushleads eseospace

Recommendations (decisive)

1. Position the brand as a **"children's book and indie-author design studio"** (illustration, covers, author websites, KDP publishing), not a "ghostwriting company".

2. Publish transparent pricing. Every competitor cost page is an opening, because buyers search "cost" before buying.
3. Make trust the main differentiator: real team, real portfolio, contracts, milestone payments, and a "how to spot a publishing scam" guide.
4. Verify the "Est." numbers in DataForSEO (US database) before the build. Re-sort pages if actual KD or volume differs by more than 2x.

Caveats and Assumptions

- No live DataForSEO pull was possible. All "Est." volume, KD and CPC figures are judgement-based ranges and need verifying. AdTargeting figures are global and dated (page copyright 2022), and its PD is paid difficulty, not organic KD. adtargeting
- SERP observations come from research-time searches and can vary by location and personalization.
- Assumptions: a new or young domain with few backlinks; a team that can deliver US-quality illustration, design and web work; a modest link-building budget; and a primary market of US self-publishing authors, with UK/CA/AU as secondary.
- Price benchmarks (illustration $2,000–$10,000 for a full picture book per Reedsy's marketplace data, or $1,540–$4,950 for a 24-page book; Reedsy editing rates; agency ghostwriting $56k–$250k) come from vendor and marketplace pages, which have commercial motives.

Final Priority Ranking of the 8 Services

1. **Children's book (writing + illustration + publishing bundle)**: BEST
2. **Book cover design**: BEST
3. **Author website**: BEST (fastest win)
4. **Illustrations (general)**: GOOD, folded into children's and covers
5. **Editing**: GOOD (second wave, genre long-tails)
6. **Publishing on platforms (KDP/IngramSpark)**: GOOD (content hub plus service pages, not head terms)
7. **Proofreading**: LOW PRIORITY (sub-page of editing)
8. **Ghostwriting**: AVOID as an SEO lead; sell as an add-on and revisit in months 7–12

Top 10 Keywords to Target First

1. children's book illustration services
2. children's book illustrators for hire
3. how much does it cost to illustrate a children's book
4. [niche] children's book illustrator (e.g., Muslim / bilingual / watercolor)
5. author website design
6. author website design for self-published authors
7. book cover design cost
8. fantasy book cover design (then romance, thriller, children's)
9. KDP book cover design service
10. KDP publishing service for children's books